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Dear Prof. Sobel,

We submit our revision of the manuscript *Young Children's Spontaneous Comprehension of Symbol-Referent Relationships in the Graphic Domain* (CD MS CHILDDDEV-2025-1273) due on April 30th, 2026, for publication as an empirical article in *Child Development*. We would like to thank the reviewers for their valuable and thoughtful comments and are happy about all of the suggestions and questions that were raised. In the responses, we provide a detailed overview of how we reacted to your requests as well as those of the reviewers. We have continuously reacted to the points and questions of the reviewers with changes to the manuscript.

In short, we have rewritten and considerably shortened the introduction with a focus on discussing the cognitive steps required by children solving symbolic object-choice-tasks (communicative inferences & matching cue and target) and refer to the match-to-sample literature in a more focussed way. The description of the Bayesian analyses was rewritten as requested to cater to readers less familiar with the approach. The interim discussions were shortened and the main discussion section now devotes more space to the role of executive functions and working memory in solving the tasks. All minor issues and inconsistencies have been addressed.

The manuscript complies with the SRCD sociocultural policy. Relevant information regarding data collection and sample characteristics can be found on p. 10 under *General Methods - Data Collection and Setup* and also in the *Abstract*.

While the current version is fully in line with our original argument, it is now clearer, more straightforward and accessible. We hope that by making these changes we are able to fully satisfy all requests by the reviewers. Again, thank you for considering our manuscript.

Sincerely,



Gregor Kachel (PhD)

Date 21.04.2026